

UNDERSTANDING MY EMOTIONS

A Workbook for Kids with Autism Ages 8-14

Emotion Identification | Body Awareness
Calm-Down Strategies | Regulation Tools

Daniel Tesfamariam

Tools for Understanding & Managing Big Feelings

Understanding My Emotions

A Workbook for Kids with Autism Ages 8-14

Copyright 2024 Daniel Tesfamariam. All rights reserved.

No part of this book may be reproduced without permission.

Designed for neurodiverse children and their caregivers.

Consult a professional for individualized support.

MY EMOTION THERMOMETER

Color in how BIG your emotion feels right now (1 = tiny, 10 = HUGE):

10

EXPLOSION! I can't control myself

9

About to explode - need help NOW

8

Very upset - hard to think

7

Really frustrated or sad

6

Getting uncomfortable

5

Medium - I notice something

4

A little bit bothered

3

Slightly annoyed

2

Mostly calm

1

Totally calm and relaxed

Today my emotion thermometer is at: _____

The emotion I feel is: _____

What made it go up: _____

WHERE DO I FEEL EMOTIONS IN MY BODY?

Different emotions feel different in our bodies. Draw or write where YOU feel each emotion:

ANGRY:

Hot face? Tight fists? Fast heartbeat? Tense shoulders?

Where I feel it: _____

How strong (1-10): _____

SAD:

Heavy chest? Tired body? Lumpy throat? Stinging eyes?

Where I feel it: _____

How strong (1-10): _____

ANXIOUS:

Butterflies in stomach? Sweaty hands? Racing heart?

Where I feel it: _____

How strong (1-10): _____

HAPPY:

Light feeling? Warm chest? Bouncy legs? Smiling face?

Where I feel it: _____

How strong (1-10): _____

OVERWHELMED:

Buzzing head? Tingling skin? Ringing ears? Tight all over?

Where I feel it: _____

How strong (1-10): _____

IMPORTANT: There are no WRONG answers! Everyone's body is different.

Knowing where you feel emotions helps you catch them EARLY.

EMOTIONS VOCABULARY - 20 FEELINGS WORDS

Happy:	Feeling good, smiling, things are going well
Sad:	Feeling down, wanting to cry, things feel heavy
Angry:	Feeling hot, wanting to yell or hit, unfair things happened
Scared:	Feeling afraid, wanting to run away or hide
Anxious:	Worried about something that MIGHT happen
Frustrated:	Trying hard but things won't work, stuck
Excited:	Can't wait! Lots of energy, happy about something coming
Embarrassed:	Wanting to disappear, face feels hot, others are looking
Jealous:	Wanting what someone else has, feels unfair
Lonely:	Feeling alone even around people, wanting connection
Bored:	Nothing seems interesting, time goes slowly
Overwhelmed:	Too much happening, brain overloaded, can't process
Disappointed:	Expected something good but it didn't happen
Proud:	Did something difficult, feeling good about myself
Confused:	Don't understand, brain feels foggy, need help
Calm:	Body relaxed, brain quiet, feeling peaceful
Disgusted:	Something gross, want to get away from it
Surprised:	Didn't expect that! Can be good or bad surprise
Grateful:	Feeling thankful for something or someone
Guilty:	Did something wrong, stomach feels bad, want to fix it

Circle the 5 emotions you feel MOST OFTEN.

TRIGGER TRACKING WORKSHEET

A TRIGGER is something that makes a big emotion start.

When you know your triggers, you can prepare for them!

What happened?	How I felt	How big? (1-10)	What I did

MY TOP 3 TRIGGERS:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

MELTDOWN vs TANTRUM - WHAT'S THE DIFFERENCE?

Sometimes people think a meltdown is 'bad behavior.' It is NOT.

A meltdown is your brain's OVERLOAD response. Here's the difference:

MELTDOWN:

- Happens when your brain gets TOO MUCH input
- You CANNOT control it (it's like a computer crashing)
- You feel WORSE during and after
- It can happen even when you're alone
- You need LESS input and a safe space to recover
- It is NOT your fault

TANTRUM:

- Happens to get something you want
- Stops when you get what you want
- You're somewhat in control of it
- Needs an audience

IMPORTANT MESSAGE: If you have meltdowns, you are NOT bad.

Your brain processes the world differently. That's okay.

The goal is to recognize the WARNING SIGNS early so you can get to a safe place BEFORE full overload.

My early warning signs that a meltdown is coming:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

What helps me during a meltdown:

MY EARLY WARNING SIGNS

Before a BIG emotion takes over, your body gives you CLUES.

Check the signs that happen to YOU:

- ☐ My face gets hot or red
- ☐ My hands make fists
- ☐ My stomach hurts or feels tight
- ☐ I feel like crying
- ☐ I want to run away or hide
- ☐ I start talking louder or faster
- ☐ I can't sit still / need to move
- ☐ I cover my ears
- ☐ Everything seems TOO LOUD
- ☐ Lights seem TOO BRIGHT
- ☐ I can't think of words
- ☐ I start picking at my skin or nails
- ☐ I feel dizzy or lightheaded
- ☐ I want to be completely alone
- ☐ I feel like hitting or throwing things

My personal warning signs not listed above:

MY CALM-DOWN TOOLKIT

When emotions get big, THESE are my tools. Choose what works for YOU:

BODY TOOLS (things I can DO):

- ☐ Jump on trampoline
- ☐ Squeeze a stress ball
- ☐ Do wall push-ups
- ☐ Swing on swing
- ☐ Run or walk fast
- ☐ Wrap up in weighted blanket
- ☐ Take deep breaths (smell flowers, blow candles)
- ☐ Do animal walks (bear, crab)

SENSORY TOOLS (things I can FEEL/HEAR/SEE):

- ☐ Listen to calm music
- ☐ Squeeze putty or slime
- ☐ Smell a calming scent
- ☐ Look at a lava lamp or glitter jar
- ☐ Hold something cold (ice pack)
- ☐ Put on noise-canceling headphones
- ☐ Chew gum or crunchy snack

THINKING TOOLS (things I can THINK):

- ☐ Count backward from 20
- ☐ Name 5 blue things I can see
- ☐ Think about my favorite place
- ☐ Say my calm-down phrase
- ☐ Remember: this feeling will pass

MY TOP 3 GO-TO TOOLS: 1. _____ 2. _____ 3. _____

5-POINT SCALE FOR MY EMOTIONS

For each emotion, fill in what each level looks/feels like FOR YOU:

ANGRY:

- 5 = Rage (hitting, screaming, breaking things)
- 4 = Very angry (yelling, stomping, can't think)
- 3 = Mad (arguing, complaining loudly)
- 2 = Annoyed (huffing, eye-rolling, short answers)
- 1 = Calm (no anger, relaxed, peaceful)

What helps me come DOWN: _____

ANXIOUS:

- 5 = Panic (can't breathe, can't move, frozen)
- 4 = Very worried (stomach hurts, want to escape)
- 3 = Nervous (thinking about bad things happening)
- 2 = A little uneasy (something feels off)
- 1 = Calm (not worried at all)

What helps me come DOWN: _____

SAD:

- 5 = Crying hard, can't stop, hopeless
- 4 = Very sad, teary, don't want to do anything
- 3 = Down, heavy feeling, low energy
- 2 = A little sad but managing
- 1 = Not sad, feeling okay or happy

What helps me come DOWN: _____

ZONES OF REGULATION

All zones are OKAY. The goal is to KNOW which zone you are in and have tools to get to the zone you NEED to be in.

BLUE ZONE (low energy):

Feelings: Sad, tired, bored, sick, shut down

Tools to use:

- Move your body (jumping jacks, dancing)
- Eat a healthy snack
- Splash cold water on face
- Talk to someone
- Get fresh air/sunlight

GREEN ZONE (just right!):

Feelings: Calm, focused, happy, ready to learn

Tools to use:

- This is where we want to be for learning!
- Keep doing what's working!
- Notice what got you here - do more of that

YELLOW ZONE (heightened):

Feelings: Frustrated, anxious, excited, silly, wiggly

Tools to use:

- Deep breathing
- Take a movement break
- Use fidget tool
- Count to 10
- Get a drink of water

RED ZONE (extremely high):

Feelings: Rage, terror, meltdown, out of control

Tools to use:

- STOP - go to safe space immediately
- Use TIPP (cold water, exercise)
- Squeeze ice
- Do NOT try to talk or solve problems yet
- Wait until back in Yellow or Green to discuss

SENSORY SUPPORTS FOR EACH EMOTION

Different emotions need different sensory input to calm down:

When ANGRY (need to release energy):

- Heavy work: push-ups, carry heavy books
- Chew crunchy food (carrots, pretzels)
- Rip paper or squeeze clay
- Stomp feet or march
- Scream into a pillow

When ANXIOUS (need to feel safe):

- Deep pressure: weighted blanket, tight hug
- Slow rocking or swinging
- Calming scents (lavender)
- Soft music or white noise
- Small enclosed space (tent, closet)

When SAD (need comfort):

- Warm bath or shower
- Soft textures (fuzzy blanket, stuffed animal)
- Gentle music
- Warm drink
- Being near a safe person (no talking needed)

When OVERWHELMED (need LESS input):

- Noise-canceling headphones
- Dark room or sunglasses
- Remove yourself from the situation
- One sense at a time (focus on breathing only)
- Do NOT add more sensory input

SOCIAL STORY: SOMEONE CHANGED THE PLAN

Marcus was told they would go to the park after school.

But when school ended, Mom said they had to go to the store first.

Marcus felt his stomach get tight and his face get hot.

He wanted to yell 'NO! You SAID the park!'

What Marcus can do:

- Take 3 deep breaths before speaking
- Say: 'I'm upset because the plan changed. Can we still go to the park after?'
- Remember: changed plans are not CANCELLED plans
- It's OKAY to feel upset. It's NOT okay to hit or scream.

What would YOU do if this happened to you?

SOCIAL STORY: SOMEONE IS BEING TOO LOUD

Aisha is in the cafeteria. It's very loud.

The noise feels like needles in her ears.

Her body is getting tense and she wants to cover her ears and run.

She's at a level 7 on her emotion thermometer.

What Aisha can do:

- Put on noise-reducing earplugs (it's okay to use them!)
- Ask a teacher to eat in a quieter spot
- Take 5 deep breaths to bring her level down
- Leave for 2 minutes to a quiet hallway, then come back

What would YOU do if this happened to you?

SOCIAL STORY: I MADE A MISTAKE IN FRONT OF EVERYONE

Jordan answered a question wrong in class.

Some kids laughed. Jordan's face turned red.

Jordan wanted to disappear. The embarrassment was at level 8.

Jordan thought: 'I'm so stupid. Everyone thinks I'm dumb.'

The truth is:

- EVERYONE makes mistakes. Even teachers.
- Most kids forgot about it in 5 minutes
- Making mistakes is how brains LEARN
- One wrong answer does NOT mean you are stupid

What would YOU think if you saw someone else make a mistake?

SOCIAL STORY: I CAN'T STOP THINKING ABOUT SOMETHING

Sam keeps thinking about something scary that MIGHT happen.

The thought goes around and around like a hamster wheel.

Sam can't focus on anything else. Anxiety is at level 6.

Sam's stomach hurts and hands are sweaty.

What Sam can do:

- Name it: 'I'm having a worry thought'
- Ask: 'Is this happening RIGHT NOW?' (Usually no!)
- Do the 5-4-3-2-1 grounding (5 things I see, 4 hear, etc.)
- Tell a trusted adult: 'I can't stop worrying about...'

What helps YOU when your brain gets stuck on a thought?

SOCIAL STORY: SOMEONE WON'T PLAY WITH ME

Alex asked three kids to play at recess. They all said no.

Alex feels sad and lonely. The feeling is at level 6.

Alex thinks: 'Nobody likes me. I'll never have friends.'

The truth is:

- Sometimes people say no for reasons that aren't about you
- They might already be in the middle of a game
- One day of 'no' doesn't mean 'never'
- You can: ask different people, play alone (that's okay too!),
or ask a teacher to help you join a group

What would YOU do if this happened to you?

COOL-DOWN SEQUENCE (Do These Steps in Order!)

STEP 1: STOP

Freeze your body. Don't do anything yet.

STEP 2: NAME IT

What emotion am I feeling? How big is it (1-10)?

STEP 3: BREATHE

Smell the flowers (in through nose 4 counts).

Blow out the candles (out through mouth 6 counts). Do this 3 times.

STEP 4: CHOOSE A TOOL

Pick ONE tool from your toolkit.

Do it for at least 2 minutes.

STEP 5: CHECK

Am I calmer? If yes, great! If no, try a different tool.

STEP 6: THINK

Now that I'm calmer, what do I need? Do I need:

- To talk to someone? - To be alone? - To solve a problem?

STEP 7: ACT

Now you can respond. Use calm words.

Remember: you can feel angry AND still be kind.

Practice this sequence EVERY DAY when calm so it becomes automatic!

AFTER THE STORM - REFLECTION PAGE

Fill this out AFTER you've calmed down from a big emotion:

Date: _____

What happened (just the facts):

What emotion did I feel? _____

How big was it (1-10)? _____

What did my body feel like? _____

What did I DO? _____

Did my reaction help or make things worse? _____

What tool from my toolkit could I try next time?

Am I okay now? (circle) YES / MOSTLY / NOT YET

Do I need to talk to someone? YES / NO

Do I need to apologize to anyone? YES / NO (Who? _____)

IMPORTANT: Having big emotions does NOT make you bad.

You are learning. Every time you practice, it gets easier.

MY SAFE PERSON & SAFE PLACE

MY SAFE PEOPLE (adults I trust when emotions are big):

Person 1: _____ Where to find them: _____

Person 2: _____ Where to find them: _____

Person 3: _____ Where to find them: _____

Person 4: _____ Where to find them: _____

What I need from my safe person:

- ☐ Just sit with me quietly (don't talk)
- ☐ Give me a hug or deep pressure
- ☐ Help me use my breathing
- ☐ Take me to my safe place
- ☐ Help me problem-solve AFTER I'm calm

MY SAFE PLACE (where I can go to calm down):

At home: _____

At school: _____

Other: _____

What I need in my safe place:

- ☐ Quiet (no loud noises)
- ☐ Dim lighting
- ☐ Soft things to touch
- ☐ Space to move
- ☐ Weighted blanket or cushions
- ☐ Headphones

MY EMOTION JOURNAL - Page 1

Date: _____ Time: _____

Emotion: _____ Level (1-10): _____

What happened: _____

Tool I used: _____

Did it help? (circle) YES / A LITTLE / NO

Level after using tool (1-10): _____

Date: _____ Time: _____

Emotion: _____ Level (1-10): _____

What happened: _____

Tool I used: _____

Did it help? (circle) YES / A LITTLE / NO

Level after using tool (1-10): _____

Date: _____ Time: _____

Emotion: _____ Level (1-10): _____

What happened: _____

Tool I used: _____

Did it help? (circle) YES / A LITTLE / NO

Level after using tool (1-10): _____

MY EMOTION JOURNAL - Page 2

Date: _____ Time: _____

Emotion: _____ Level (1-10): _____

What happened: _____

Tool I used: _____

Did it help? (circle) YES / A LITTLE / NO

Level after using tool (1-10): _____

Date: _____ Time: _____

Emotion: _____ Level (1-10): _____

What happened: _____

Tool I used: _____

Did it help? (circle) YES / A LITTLE / NO

Level after using tool (1-10): _____

Date: _____ Time: _____

Emotion: _____ Level (1-10): _____

What happened: _____

Tool I used: _____

Did it help? (circle) YES / A LITTLE / NO

Level after using tool (1-10): _____

MY EMOTION JOURNAL - Page 3

Date: _____ Time: _____

Emotion: _____ Level (1-10): _____

What happened: _____

Tool I used: _____

Did it help? (circle) YES / A LITTLE / NO

Level after using tool (1-10): _____

Date: _____ Time: _____

Emotion: _____ Level (1-10): _____

What happened: _____

Tool I used: _____

Did it help? (circle) YES / A LITTLE / NO

Level after using tool (1-10): _____

Date: _____ Time: _____

Emotion: _____ Level (1-10): _____

What happened: _____

Tool I used: _____

Did it help? (circle) YES / A LITTLE / NO

Level after using tool (1-10): _____

MY EMOTION JOURNAL - Page 4

Date: _____ Time: _____

Emotion: _____ Level (1-10): _____

What happened: _____

Tool I used: _____

Did it help? (circle) YES / A LITTLE / NO

Level after using tool (1-10): _____

Date: _____ Time: _____

Emotion: _____ Level (1-10): _____

What happened: _____

Tool I used: _____

Did it help? (circle) YES / A LITTLE / NO

Level after using tool (1-10): _____

Date: _____ Time: _____

Emotion: _____ Level (1-10): _____

What happened: _____

Tool I used: _____

Did it help? (circle) YES / A LITTLE / NO

Level after using tool (1-10): _____

MY EMOTION JOURNAL - Page 5

Date: _____ Time: _____

Emotion: _____ Level (1-10): _____

What happened: _____

Tool I used: _____

Did it help? (circle) YES / A LITTLE / NO

Level after using tool (1-10): _____

Date: _____ Time: _____

Emotion: _____ Level (1-10): _____

What happened: _____

Tool I used: _____

Did it help? (circle) YES / A LITTLE / NO

Level after using tool (1-10): _____

Date: _____ Time: _____

Emotion: _____ Level (1-10): _____

What happened: _____

Tool I used: _____

Did it help? (circle) YES / A LITTLE / NO

Level after using tool (1-10): _____

MY EMOTION REGULATION PLAN

This is MY plan. I made it. I can use it anytime.

My name: _____

My biggest emotion challenge: _____

My #1 trigger: _____

My early warning signs: _____

My 3 best calm-down tools:

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

My safe place: _____

My safe person: _____

My calm-down phrase: _____

(Examples: 'This will pass' / 'I can handle this' / 'I am safe')

I WILL ask for help when my level reaches: _____

I deserve to feel calm and happy. I am learning every day.

A MESSAGE FOR YOU

Dear Reader,

Having big emotions is not a bad thing.

It means you feel things deeply. That is a **STRENGTH**.

Your brain works differently from some other kids.

That does not mean it works **WRONG**.

It means the world wasn't designed for your brain,

so you have to work a little harder sometimes.

That's not fair. But you are stronger than you know.

Some days will be hard. Some days you will feel

overwhelmed or frustrated or sad.

That's okay. Those feelings will pass.

You are not 'too much.'

You are not 'broken.'

You are not 'bad.'

You are a person who is **LEARNING**.

And every single day you practice,

it gets a tiny bit easier.

Be patient with yourself.

You are doing great.

- This workbook believes in you.